ECONOMY & POLITICS

Does migration move voters to the right?

Studies that follow where newcomers actually settled find an effect, but its size and even its direction depend on contact.

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A worn suitcase beside empty chairs in a waiting room. · AI-generated image

Migration routes do not just rewrite demographics; they change the chemistry of the ballot box. But exactly how? The question usually gets lost in the noise of political polling; we find the answer instead in those quiet, experimental periods when the state, not the migrants, decided where people would settle.

Denmark's policy from 1986 to 1998 holds up a clear mirror. When refugees were placed in municipalities with little regard for local politics, studies found that in most municipalities, receiving more refugees raised support for anti-immigration parties. In the largest and most urban municipalities, however, the effect went the other way. [1] A similar wind blew through Austria: where more immigrants lived, worries about jobs and about the quality of neighbourhoods channelled votes to the far-right Freedom Party, especially when the newcomers had little formal education. [2]

The core of the issue, however, lies in the depth of contact. During the 2015 refugee movement, places where refugees merely passed through Austria – a brief, superficial exposure – saw support for the far right rise. But where asylum seekers stayed for months and became neighbours you might bump into at the grocery store, that support fell slightly. [3] The Greek islands in 2015 confirm this: on shores suddenly reached by refugee boats, the far-right Golden Dawn gained about two percentage points more than on similar islands farther away. [4] In short, migration's rightward pull is real but modest – a shift of a few points, not a landslide. Suddenness and unfamiliarity breed fear, whereas time, familiarity and sharing the same street can soften that sharp political edge. Most of this evidence, though, comes from Europe and from refugees rather than labour migrants, so it should travel to other places with care.

Sources

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